

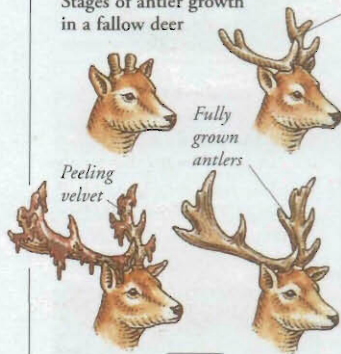
DEER AND ANTELOPES



THE MOST noticeable difference between deer and antelopes is in their headgear. Deer have branched antlers that

are shed, whereas antelopes have unbranched horns that are permanent. Both deer and antelopes are herbivorous hoofed mammals. They look similar to each other, but belong to different families. Deer are in a family of their own, while antelopes belong to the cattle family. They include gazelles, duikers, and spiral-horned antelopes.

Stages of antler growth in a fallow deer



Growing antlers

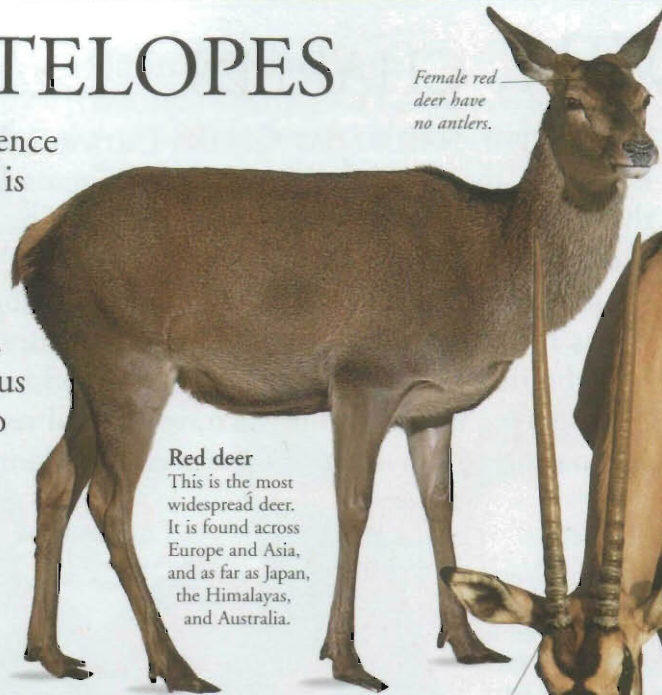
Antlers

The larger a stag's antlers, the more females it will attract. While the antlers are growing, they are protected by a velvety skin, richly supplied with blood vessels and nerves. At the end of the deer's breeding season, the blood supply to the antlers is cut off, causing the velvet to dry out and peel off in strips.

Deer

There are 38 species of deer spread over most of Europe, as well as Asia, North Africa, and the Americas. Some have been introduced into Australasia. Most species live in herds that split up in the breeding season. Most male deer, or stags, bear multi-branched antlers, which are shed and regrown every year.

Female red deer have no antlers.



Red deer

This is the most widespread deer. It is found across Europe and Asia, and as far as Japan, the Himalayas, and Australia.

Both sexes have long, straight horns.



Fringe-eared oryx

Oryx live in the arid grasslands of Tanzania and Kenya, in Africa. They obtain water from roots and tubers.

Antelopes

Most of the 60 species of antelope live in Africa. Some, such as the blackbuck and the Tibetan antelope, are Asian. A few species have been introduced to other countries. Antelopes range in size from the giant Derby eland to the pygmy and royal antelopes, which are no bigger than hares.

Antelope horns

All male antelopes have horns, but only some females. The males use their horns to intimidate their rivals and to defend their territory.



Horns are hollow.



Front view of hartebeest horns



Front view of greater kudu horns



Browsing antelope



Grazing gazelles

Four-horned antelope

Males have two pairs of horns, making the deer a sought-after trophy for hunters. The front pair of horns is smaller than the back pair.

Nyala

The nyala, found in southeast African forests, has dark brown horns with a white tip. These can be up to 78 cm (31 in) long, with usually one open curve.

Hartebeest

Both male and female hartebeests have curved horns. Each has about 12 ridges but a smooth tip. Seen from the front, the horns are angular.

Greater kudu

The triple-spiralled horns of the male greater kudu are among the most imposing horns of any living animal. They grow up to 1.5 m (5 ft) long.

Roan antelope

Males and females have horns. About 55 cm (22 in) long, they are strongly ridged and curve gradually backward.

Largest and smallest deer

The largest of all deer is the moose of North America, known as the elk in Europe. An adult male moose may stand 1.8 m (6 ft) at the shoulder and weigh 545 kg (1,200 lbs). The smallest deer is the South American pudu, which stands only about 40 cm (16 in) at the shoulder and weighs about 9 kg (20 lbs).



Père David's deer

This deer once lived wild in China. Then, for 3,000 years, it existed only in parks. In 1865, the missionary Père David saw the last surviving herd. This herd was later wiped out, but the Duke of Bedford established a herd in England. In recent years, deer bred in captivity have been sent to China and reintroduced into a special reserve.



Browsers and grazers

The antelopes include both grazing and browsing species. In Africa, for example, some species, such as Thomson's gazelle, graze on grass. Other species, such as the gerenuk, browse the leaves and shoots of trees. Grant's and dorcas gazelles browse and graze, according to what is available.